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Synthesizing Pedagogy and Cognitive Architecture for Autonomous AI Reliability

From "Diagnose-Then-Teach" to Closed-Loop Rational Governance

Zhao Wan
Department of Computer Science

Cognitive Systems Engineering Group
Cosmos Analytics AI Laboratory

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ABSTRACT

Deploying frozen Large Language Models (LLMs) in high-stakes autonomous settings exposes two catastrophic failure modes: **domain ignorance** (failing to execute task-specific conventions) and **uncalibrated over-compliance** (blindly prioritizing prompt rules over empirical runtime evidence). Recently, two distinct frameworks have emerged to address these failure modes without costly parameter retraining: (1) the *Educational Approach* (Wan, 2026), which formalizes in-context prompt engineering as diagnostic test preparation (*Diagnose-Then-Teach*), and (2) the *Cognitive Architecture Approach*, which bounds LLMs with a tri-harness biological brain model (*KNOW, BE SURE, ACT*). In this paper, we demonstrate the deep theoretical equivalence of both paradigms, isolate where the cognitive approach systematically overcomes the structural limitations of the educational model, and synthesize them into a unified production architecture: the **Educated Cognitive Agent (ECA)**. We demonstrate that combining pre-run diagnostic baseline discovery with dynamic dual-graph grounding, multi-rollout conflict monitoring, and loss-weighted Bayes risk gating produces an autonomous agent that is both epistemically sound and instrumentally rational.

Keywords: AI Reliability, In-Context Learning, Cognitive Architecture, Metacognition, Bounded Headroom, Bayes Risk Gate, Tri-Graph Governance.

1. INTRODUCTION & THE RELIABILITY PROBLEM

Modern foundation models operate as frozen computational cores during production inference. When tasked with complex, mission-critical operations—such as software bug repair, automated insurance underwriting, or clinical prior authorization—standard models fail in repeatable, brittle ways. Traditional remedies rely on weight fine-tuning or post-training alignment; however, model retraining is computationally prohibitive, induces catastrophic forgetting, and alters general reasoning representations unpredictably.

Consequently, practitioners rely on in-context instructions (system prompts, rulebooks, SOPs). However, in-context instruction often introduces new vulnerabilities: prompt bloat, attention dilution, cross-rule interference, and pathological overconfidence. To resolve this, two foundational methodologies have recently been established:

- **The Educational Paradigm (Wan, 2026):** Frames prompt engineering through the lens of pedagogical test preparation. A teacher administers a baseline diagnostic examination to detect what the student model does not know unaided; injects a targeted rulebook covering only the identified knowledge gap; and measures strict pass rates against an independent, hidden exam.
- **The Cognitive Architecture Paradigm:** Frames prompt engineering through the neurobiology of rational decision-making. The frozen LLM is bounded by three modular harnesses: (1) an *Education Harness (KNOW)* incorporating semantic memory (Cortex) and episodic memory (Hippocampus); (2) a *Calibration Harness (BE SURE)* evaluating metacognition and rollout consistency; and (3) an *Action Gate Harness (ACT)* enforcing Bayes risk thresholds before releasing decisions.

This paper bridges these two schools of thought, proving that they are complementary phases of a single, optimal cognitive control system.

2. CORE SIMILARITIES: SHARED EPISTEMOLOGICAL FOUNDATIONS

Despite differing nomenclatures (pedagogy vs. neuroscience), both approaches are grounded in four identical empirical principles:

2.1. The Principle of Bounded Headroom

Wan (2026) proved that instruction gains track the knowledge gap and are strictly bounded by headroom: **`Gain ≤ 100 − Baseline`**. When a model operates at 100% baseline, instruction yields zero gain. In the Cognitive Architecture, the Gate Harness enforces a default state of **HOLD**, suppressing prompt intervention when baseline knowledge is already saturated.

2.2. Rejection of Context Stuffing

Wan showed that supplying all 16 handbook rules caused cross-rule leakage and degraded performance below single-rule injection in 4 families. The Cognitive Architecture mirrors this via the **Hippocampus Context Graph**, which is explicitly indexed and *"opened only when needed"* rather than dumped entirely into context.

2.3. Model Idiosyncrasy (ρ = 0.46)

Claude Sonnet and Gemini 2.5 Flash exhibited only moderate correlation (`ρ = 0.46`) in their unaided baselines. A rule essential for Gemini was redundant for Claude. The Cognitive Architecture reflects this by maintaining model-specific calibration curves and localized memory graphs.

2.4. Objective Hidden Verification

Neither system trusts self-reported LLM confidence. Wan graded patches via strict hidden regression tests. The Cognitive Architecture releases actions only when calibrated confidence $\hat{P}$ satisfies the empirical Bayes risk cutoff θ^*.

3. WHERE THE COGNITIVE APPROACH ADVANCES BEYOND PURE PEDAGOGY

While the Educational Approach formalizes prompt calibration, it remains an *offline, static, open-loop* methodology. The Cognitive Architecture provides five decisive capabilities required for autonomous production runtimes:

3.1. Dynamic Dual-Graph Grounding vs. Static Handbook Injection

KNOW Harness

In Wan's experiment, the handbook is a static string injected into every prompt. In contrast, the Cognitive Architecture establishes a bi-directional dialogue between the **Semantic Cortex** (invariant domain rules) and the **Episodic Hippocampus** (precedent case index). When an active case arrives, the system retrieves only the specific precedent cluster, traverses the explicit graph links to the relevant invariant rules, and constructs a minimal, targeted prompt. This eliminates the prompt-clutter penalty where placebo text degraded Gemini's pass rate in 8 of 14 families ($p \approx 0.04$).

3.2. Metacognitive Calibration vs. Pathological Over-Compliance

BE SURE Harness

A critical vulnerability identified in Wan's experiment was that a mismatched rule caused Claude's pass rate on `service_errors` to crash from 100% unaided down to 56% (a catastrophic loss of 44 points). The model blindly prioritized the injected handbook rule over empirical evidence in the ticket traceback. The Cognitive Architecture neutralizes this via the **Prefrontal Cortex Metacognitive Calibration Map**. By calibrating stated probability against empirical ground truth, the agent evaluates whether the rule's premise holds in the current case context. If rule compliance contradicts verified invariant checks, confidence is heavily discounted, halting autonomous deployment.

3.3. Multi-Rollout Conflict Monitoring vs. Single-Attempt Sampling

Anterior Cingulate

Wan observed high variance across task seeds (e.g. `permission_prefix` task 2020 scored 2/8 with the rule vs. 7/8 unaided). Single-shot LLM inferences are vulnerable to stochastic sampling noise. The Cognitive Architecture incorporates the **Anterior Cingulate Conflict Monitor**, sampling $N = 5$ parallel candidate rollouts across diverse random seeds. If the rollout actions diverge, the system flags high entropy: *"If five answers disagree, the knowledge has not taken hold."*

3.4. Cost-Weighted Bayes Risk Gating vs. Symmetric Pass/Fail

ACT Harness

The educational model treats all errors symmetrically. However, real-world systems face asymmetric loss: accepting a corrupt financial transaction (Type 1 error) is orders of magnitude worse than temporarily withholding a valid one (Type 2 error). The Cognitive Architecture's **Gate Harness** computes the optimal risk cutoff:

$$\theta^* = \text{Cost(Type 1)} / [\ \text{Cost(Type 1)} + \text{Cost(Type 2)}\ ]$$

When calibrated confidence $\hat{P} < \theta^*$, or when encountering unsolvable edge cases (such as Wan's task 2018, which failed 0/8 across all arms), the Basal Ganglia does not emit a broken patch; it enforces **HOLD** and triggers **ESCALATE to human expert**.

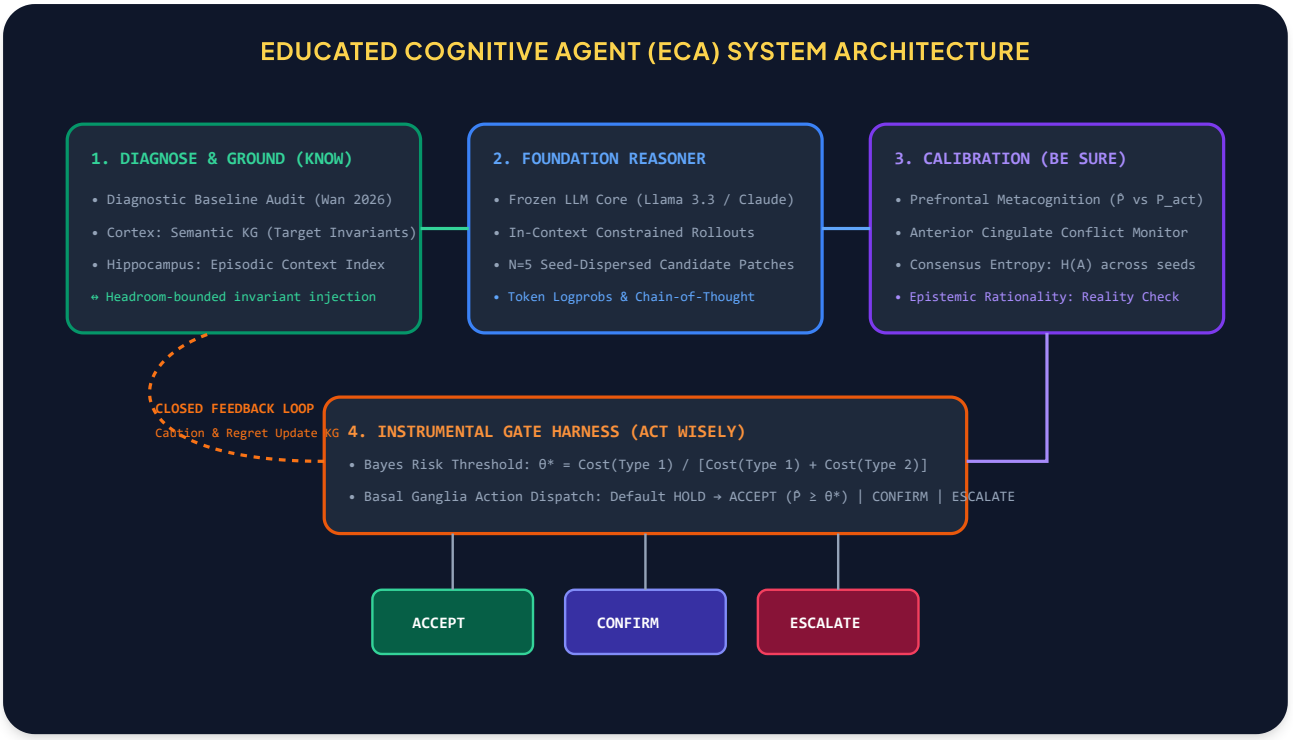
3.5. Real-Time Closed Learning Loop (Caution & Regret)

Feedback Loop

While the Educational Approach requires offline human re-authoring of the handbook after failures, the Cognitive Architecture autonomously executes closed-loop learning. A Type 1 production mistake raises the caution bar (elevating θ^* and injecting an invariant defensive guard into the Cortex), while a Type 2 error generates regret against the ground truth answer key, indexing the missed edge case into the Hippocampus.

4. THE COMBINED FRAMEWORK: THE EDUCATED COGNITIVE AGENT (ECA)

By integrating the pre-deployment diagnostic rigor of the Educational Approach with the runtime governance of the Cognitive Architecture, we arrive at a unified, production-grade architecture: the **Educated Cognitive Agent (ECA)**.



Under the ECA framework, the deployment lifecycle proceeds through four synchronized stages:

1. **Pre-Run Headroom Audit:** Invariant test suites establish the baseline pass rate B. If $B \approx 100\%$, prompt injection is completely suppressed to protect the headroom bound. If $B << 100\%$, the knowledge gap is compiled into a minimal invariant rule.
2. **Dynamic Invariant Assembly:** At runtime, incoming cases dynamically query the Hippocampus Context Graph to retrieve historical precedents, which in turn pull only the relevant Cortex rules into context.
3. **Rollout Calibration Check:** The LLM generates $N = 5$ rollouts. The Anterior Cingulate verifies consensus entropy, and the Prefrontal Cortex checks the calibration curve to prevent over-compliance.
4. **Bayes Risk Action Gating:** The Basal Ganglia checks $\hat{P} \geq \theta^*$. If the threshold is satisfied, the patch is deployed; if ambiguity remains or the task is unmastered, the action is escalated to a human specialist.

5. COMPARATIVE EVALUATION ACROSS ARCHITECTURAL DIMENSIONS

Dimension	Pure Educational Approach (Wan 2026)	Pure Cognitive Approach (Tri-Harness)	Combined Approach (ECA Framework)
Core Metaphor	Classroom Test Prep (Diagnose-Then-Teach)	Tri-Harness Biological Brain	Educated & Governed Rational Agent
Knowledge Discovery	Offline diagnostic test suite across code tasks	Continuous Ontology KG & Context Index	**Diagnostic baseline continuously updates KG rules**
Prompt Construction	Static rulebook or single rule in context	Dual-graph retrieval (Cortex + Hippocampus)	**Headroom-gated targeted invariant injection**
Context Interference	Vulnerable to handbook & placebo clutter	Selective episodic retrieval isolates memory	**Strict invariant isolation eliminates syntax leakage**
Metacognition	None (assumes model executes rules accurately)	Live calibration curve ($P_{ ext{stated}} pprox P_{ ext{actual}}$)	**Empirical Brier score calibration rejects blind obedience**
Variance Defense	Post-hoc sample counts (k/n)	Anterior Cingulate 5-rollout conflict entropy	**Multi-seed consensus gating suppresses noisy passes**
Decision Gating	Symmetric Pass/Fail (all generated patches committed)	Basal Ganglia: Default HOLD; Accept/Confirm/Escalate	**Cost-weighted Bayes risk thresholding ($ heta^*$)**
Human Integration	Benchmark author & handbook author	Escalation receiver for low-confidence events	**Autonomous for $\hat{P} \ge heta^*$; human fallback for unmastered**
Learning Loop	Offline manual handbook revision	Type 1 Caution & Type 2 Regret feedback	**Dynamic parameter updates + automated exam expansion**

6. CONCLUSION & IMPLICATIONS FOR AI ENGINEERING

The empirical findings of Zhao Wan (2026) provide an indispensable lesson for the field of agentic AI: **written instruction is fundamentally bounded by headroom, and unconstrained handbooks introduce cross-rule interference and pathological over-compliance.**

However, education alone cannot guarantee autonomous safety. Without metacognitive self-calibration (*BE SURE*), an educated model will blindly override ticket evidence; without an instrumental risk gate (*ACT*), an educated model cannot evaluate when a mistake is too costly to risk autonomous execution.

By fusing the **diagnostic precision of the Educational Approach** with the **metacognitive calibration, rollout conflict monitoring, and risk-gated execution of the Cognitive Architecture**, engineers can deploy agents that embody the complete classical definition of rationality: **they know the domain rules, they are quantitatively sure how well they know them, and they act only when the expected utility exceeds the cost of failure.**

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